

Answer First

Give the answer in the first sentence, then group the reasons beneath it, parallel reasons or a chain, never both at once, with the evidence at the leaves.

BEST FOR A CHALLENGE, A DECISION, AT THE END · BARBARA MINTO, 1970S · TAKES AN HOUR TO GET IT INTO ONE SENTENCE

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write who this is for, what they already believe, and what they will do with the answer. Then write the question they are asking, in their words. Answering a better question than the one asked reads as evasion.
2. Write the answer in one sentence. The whole recommendation, as the first thing they read. If it won't go in one sentence, go back to the thinking.
3. Write three groups beneath it, each asserting one claim in a sentence that directly holds the answer up. Order them by strength. Two groups is usually a debate; four is usually a list.
4. Fill each group with two to five supports that argue alike: all parallel reasons, or all steps in a chain. Never both in one group. Put the evidence, the fact or figure or source, behind each support.
5. Test each support: if this fell, would the claim still stand? If yes, it is colour, not support, and it moves to an appendix or goes.
6. Read it as the reader will. Write the thirty-second version: the answer, the three claims, nothing else. Then write the strongest objection and say which group answers it. If none does, you are missing a group.

Where it falls down. Answer first with nothing beneath it is an assertion, and a confident one is worse than a hesitant one.

WITH A PEN

Who it's for, and the question they're asking

The answer, in one sentence

Group 1: the claim

Parallel or chain. Supports, each with evidence. Load-bearing?

Group 2

Group 3

The thirty-second version

The answer, the three claims, nothing else

The strongest objection

And which group answers it